he wanted to meet Mullah Omar and had extensive discussions with Muttawakil as well. Any visit of a senior political figure from India to Kandahar meant tacit political signaling to the Taliban, that New Delhi is ready to engage.[146] This was, however, not advisable according to Sood.[147] Even more ill-advised was releasing those three 'goons'.[148] Singh's decision to fly to Kandahar had outraged X as well. Considering it absolutely unnecessary, X thought that Singh's visit 'was an act of bravado put up by an ex-army man who had forgotten that he was a politician. All was done and dusted by the time Singh reached Kandahar'.[149] Singh's decision to visit Kandahar, however, was a purely political call, without any input from the foreign affairs and security bureaucracy.[150] Singh admitted that 'Vivek Katju, Ajit Doval, and C. D. Sahay were not unanimous on his decision to fly to Kandahar, but they wanted someone with the authority to make spot decisions.[151] The opposition, led by Congress, kicked up a storm in the Lok Sabha over the BJP's handling of the hijacking and Singh's decision to visit Kandahar.[152]

According to Sood, 'it was exaggerated hope that we could make a breakthrough with the Taliban, the Muttawakil and types. They were not in a good mood, they had just scored a victory over you, and they had got these goons out. And they were still under considerable Pakistani control ... So there was not going to be any possibility of the Taliban coming to talk to you [India]'.[153] Indeed, the first person to be greeted and hugged by the Taliban was Masood Azhar while Singh waited. And the man waiting to receive Azhar was none other than Mullah Akhtar Mansour, who emerged as the Taliban's top leader in 2015 (and was later killed in a US drone strike in May 2016).[154] The fact that the Taliban did not allow India to undertake military action against the hijackers in Kandahar and positioned their forces in an offensive position against the Indian planes cemented the perception of Taliban-ISI nexus in Indian minds.[155] A top security official privy to the IC-814 negotiations and a key partisan, confirms:

> There was no redefining of policy vis-à-vis Afghanistan at that point. We knew that Pakistan is controlling them [Taliban]. We had lost ground in Afghanistan and there were minority views that we should talk to the Taliban, not everyone felt like that.[156]

The hijacking crisis deepened India's perception of the Taliban being Pakistan's agents. Raghunath, who had retired as the foreign secretary less than a month before the hijacking incident, disagrees with the notion that Jaswant